

Getting Glean ready for work

Designing the admin experience for setup, connectors, and actions

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 01]

Figma frame: workspace setup, DLP configuration, permissions, action creation, and action enablement.

Overview

I was the sole designer across Workspace, the Admin Console, and the Tools and Actions team. The work focused on designing the admin experience for getting Glean ready for a company: setting up the workspace, connecting data sources, configuring permissions, managing connectors, and preparing the systems people would use every day.

Team: Debby Shephard (Product Manager), Yiming Jen (Engineer), Vinke Xu (Engineer), Hans Bala (Engineer), and Neel Saswade (Designer).

Getting a company ready to use Glean

Before employees can use Glean, admins need to connect the right systems, set up access, and configure the workspace.

That work had spread across different surfaces and teams. The goal was to make the path from initial setup to ongoing management easier to understand.

([Workspace Design Wiki](#); [Workspace design transition doc](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 02]

The admin journey: setup, connectors, permissions, governance, actions, apps, and workflows.

Understanding the admin

I studied the people responsible for setting up and managing Glean.

The research covered their workflows, recurring tasks, tools, pain points, and levels of technical fluency. It led to clearer admin archetypes and a stronger distinction between setup admins, security teams, and other workspace operators.

([Admin Persona User Research Study](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 03]

Admin research synthesis: responsibilities, workflows, and points of friction.

Structuring the admin experience

Workspace brought together setup, connectors, authentication, teammates, permissions, usage, and governance.

I organized those responsibilities into a more coherent experience while accounting for caching, asynchronous changes, multiple backend services, and third-party setup requirements.

([Workspace Design Wiki](#); [Workspace design transition doc](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 04]

Workspace information architecture and navigation.

Making DLP self-serve

Data Loss Prevention reporting helped customers find sensitive or overexposed content.

The original workflow depended on manual coordination and restricted infrastructure access. The self-serve direction moved the work into the product: configure what to scan, run the report, download it securely, and manage its lifecycle.

([Making DLP self-serve PRD](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 05]

DLP setup flow: configure, run, download, and delete.

Designing for ongoing management

The DLP experience made important constraints visible: one report at a time, configuration changes applying to the next run, audit logging, notifications, and file deletion.

Customers could configure, schedule, download, and delete their own reports instead of relying on Glean employees to generate them.

([Making DLP self-serve PRD](#))

Connecting Glean to work

The Tools experience extended the admin problem into actions.

Actions needed to work across Glean Apps and Workflows while supporting different authentication models and levels of technical experience. Actions V2 treated setup and management as a system rather than a collection of screens.

([Tools redesign](#); [Actions V2 design solution](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 06]

Tools to Actions evolution.

Supporting every Actions role

Actions had to work for creators building them, enablers making them available, selectors choosing them inside an app or workflow, and end users running them. Each role needed a different level of control. The framework connected those paths without forcing everyone through the same setup flow.

([Actions V2 PRD](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 07]

Actions role model: creation, enablement, selection, and execution.

Making Actions easier to configure

Glean-provided actions could include default configuration. Action packs grouped related actions by data source. Builders could define custom actions, inspect model behavior, and test inputs before making them available.

Configuration and validation moved closer together so people could understand what an action would do before using it.

([Actions V2 design solution](#); [Anusha / Neel Actions notes](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 08]

Action creation, preview, and test loop.

From setup to use

Workspace and Actions addressed different parts of Glean, but the admin journey connected them.

Admins could configure the workspace, connect systems, set permissions, enable capabilities, and make those capabilities available to employees.

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 09]

Shared journey across configuration, authorization, execution, feedback, and recovery.

The impact

The work moved important parts of getting Glean ready toward self-service.

DLP customers could manage their own reports. Actions gained a clearer framework for creation, enablement, selection, and execution across Glean Apps and Workflows.

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 10]

Strongest final screens across Workspace, DLP, and Actions.

What came next

The admin experience continues to expand as more of Glean becomes configurable and connected. The patterns from this work provide a foundation for clearer setup, system state, and ongoing management.

Co-authored with Glean